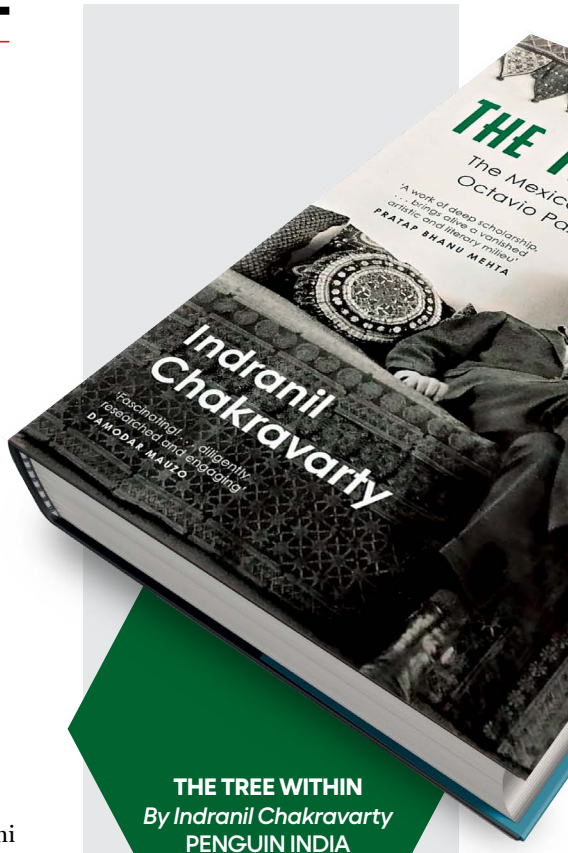
BOOKS ▼

A WIDE-ANGLE PERSPECTIVE

INDRANIL CHAKRAVARTY'S *THE TREE WITHIN*—ABOUT OCTAVIO PAZ'S YEARS IN INDIA—ALSO THROWS LIGHT ON THE CULTURAL MILIEU OF DELHI IN THE 1960s



INDRANIL CHAKRAVARTY'S study of the 1990 Nobel Laureate Octavio Paz's years in India is much more than a detailed and intimate study of the many years Paz spent in India as Mexico's ambassador. It is, alongside, a perspective on literary and cultural circles in India and especially New Delhi in the 1960s as seen through the eyes of a perceptive foreign observer.

The Tree Within also has the great merit of providing a wide-angle perspective on the relationship between India and the Hispanic world—not something easily encountered in our Anglo-Saxon-dominated discourse. Finally, the book will be of special interest to many in India because Paz occupies an unusual, perhaps even unique, perch. Indranil Chakravarty points out: "It is difficult to find similar cases in our history when a major creative figure from abroad drew inspiration from Indian culture for one's own works over such an extended time."

Paz would come to refer to India as the land where he had his 'second birth'. But in his first interface with the country, he disliked it intensely. In Mexico's diplomatic service and with a growing reputation as a poet he was posted to New Delhi in 1951 after a very creative and productive six years in Paris. He saw Delhi as a punishment, which it was. Being a junior diplomat in Delhi in its set hierarchies at that time could be difficult. Paz was to write to a friend: "Here nobody is interested in art, nobody seems to have heard of Baudelaire and the word poetry means only Tagore." Fortunately for him, the ordeal was brief as Paz was posted out in six months.

> Chakravarty is **not an uncritical admirer of Paz. For instance,** he notes that on occasion Paz's gaze would be somewhat 'Orientalist in the Saidian sense'

A decade later, Paz was back and was to spend about six years as ambassador of Mexico. His life here was immensely creative and some of his best-known works (*The Monkey Grammarian*, for instance) are the outcome of this period. Chakravarty sensitively brings out the personal and not so personal reasons for the change in Paz's views about India and just how he grew so engaged with this country of posting. His literary reputation enhanced his political and diplomatic access in many ways. His friends circle in New Delhi is like a listing of the who's who of Indian culture and art of the time: the painters Gulam Sheikh, Satish Gujral, Vivan Sundaram, J. Swaminathan; the writers Raja Rao, Mulk Raj Anand; editors like Romesh Thapar and